

Learn to Be a Great Communicator: Introduction, featuring Virginia Means

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Coach Summitt said, “By *communicate effectively*, what I mean is how can you best command the attention of those you are speaking to? Decide what you’re trying to accomplish, whether you’re trying to motivate, elicit a confession, ask for a raise, or instill confidence. Be clear on what you want to say and say it in a way that’s appropriate to your surroundings.”

To better understand the challenge and opportunity of leadership communication, consider this reality. First, most leaders spend the majority of their time each day in some type of interpersonal behavior, communicating with team or staff, other managers, customers, or other stakeholders. Second, a substantial number of organizational difficulties occur as a result of ineffective communication or no communication at all. This is why effective communication is an essential element of leadership success, whether it’s interpersonal, group, organizational, or external in nature.

Great communicators are great listeners – you’re going to hear that again -- perceptive in their observations and skilled at discerning the feelings, concerns, and priorities of others. The message isn’t about who delivers the message. It is, however, about delivering the right message to the right person in the right way. There’s a difference between merely talking and communicating. Words with no meaning will not provide communication, understanding, and a response. There needs to be a purpose behind every word, sentence, and expression.

Talking is the least of it. If you really want to get something across, body language, facial expression, eye contact, and listening are all necessary parts of communication.

In this series, we’ll invest our time in three key areas that dramatically impact our ability to effectively communicate. We’ll examine why authenticity, relationships, and nonverbal communication are all critically important on our quest to be effective communicators.